

A big-circulation European magazine recently published a cartoon which depicted a camera-draped American tourist and a tourist-guide standing in front of some Greek temple ruins. "First World War or Second?" the caption had the American asking.

Although this may not sound very funny to you or me, the cartoon was widely reprinted all over the Continent.

Countless Europeans laughed heartily at what they considered a telling lampoon of the typical American tourist. While foreigners have long acknowledged and acclaimed American leadership—and even supremacy—in science and technology, they have often been highly amused by the cultural illiteracy so often displayed by Americans and particularly by American men.

The curator of a famous French art museum tells me that he can instantly single out most American men in even the largest and most heterogeneous crowds that come to his galleries. "It's all in their walk," he claims. "The moment the average American male steps through the doors, he assumes a truculently self-conscious half-strut, half-shamble that tries to say: 'I don't really want to be here. I'd much rather be in a bar or watching a baseball game.'"

In my own opinion, the average American's cultural shortcomings can be likened to those of the educated barbarians of ancient Rome. These were barbarians who learned to speak—and often to read and write—Latin.

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They acquired Roman habits of dress and deportment.

Many of them handily mastered Roman commercial, engineering and military techniques—but they remained barbarians nonetheless. They failed to develop any understanding, appreciation or love for the art and culture of the great civilization around them.

The culture-shunning American male has been a carica-tourists' cliché for decades, at home as well as abroad—and with good reason. The traditional